

2000-2009

The DECADE that changed the world LowCostTransport

was used to travel in jeeps and tractors. Now because rural roads have improved they are going in for cars. From 1.5 to 2 lakh car sales in the 1980s, we are selling a million-and-a-half cars today. Liberalisation further opened up the automobile market for foreign manufacturers to venture into India. Excise duty was brought down from 60 to 8 per cent, making cars more affordable. In fact, today India is an international hub for the manufacture of small cars. In couple of years, we should be exporting a million cars. Design and R&D too will follow. GM has 3,000 people working at its R&D

transport and except a few states, it has been an area of neglect. It is mostly a politicised issue. If you don't charge the right fares, the quality of transportation keeps deteriorating. I feel the public is willing to pay market rates if you give them better service. Look at the Delhi Metro.

Another unfortunate thing in India is that in the last 50 years we haven't spent enough money on the Railways. For instance, every year, China lays down thou-

THE DELHI METRO HAS MADE COMMUTING FASTER, COMFORTABLE AND PERHAPS CHEAPER TOO



ANANDITO MUKHERJEE

WITH LOW-COST FLIGHTS,
we will be the Udupi hotels of
the airline business.

**G.R. GOPINATH,
MD, AIR DECCAN**

centre here in Bangalore. Maruti Suzuki is strengthening its R&D wing. This is really a transportation revolution. Where once we used to import full vehicles, we are now exporting vehicles. We are developing our R&D and in seven to 10 years, will become very strong in designing and engineering. All this has happened in the last 20 years.

Even though I am from the automobile industry, I am a great supporter of public transportation. India needs strong public

sands of kilometres of new railway lines. It is in fact, aiming to build a total operational length of 1,10,000 km in railway tracks by 2012, up from 80,000 km at the end of 2008. What about us? All we did was tackle the low hanging fruit: increase freight, reduce halting time and increase the number of wagons. But as far as modernisation of tracks, rolling stocks, signals and safety matters are concerned, not much has been done. Clearly this government hasn't paid as much attention to the Railways as it has to the NHAI. Railway are important to India's growth because they are cost-effective and more environment-friendly when compared to roadways.

Like the Railways, airline safety is also a critical issue. They say the average age of a fleet shows the quality of an airline. The age of the Emirates' or Singapore Airlines'

Blazing New TRAILS

2002 The first section of Delhi Metro is inaugurated. Till date, three lines in Phase 1 are operational.

2003 India's first low-cost, no-frills airline, Air Deccan, flies maiden flight between Hyderabad and Vijaywada.



2007 Kingfisher merges with Air Deccan and starts a low-cost option.

2008 Greenfield airports at Hyderabad and Bengaluru usher in a new era of world class airport infrastructure.



2009 In Mumbai, the Bandra-Worli sea link, a 5.6-km road across the Arabian Sea, connecting the island city and its north-western suburbs, opens.

2009 The airline boom goes bust. Private airlines contemplate a strike but back down after a government warning.